

WAR SITES

OF THE 1914-1918 CAMPAIGN
BELGIAN ARMY



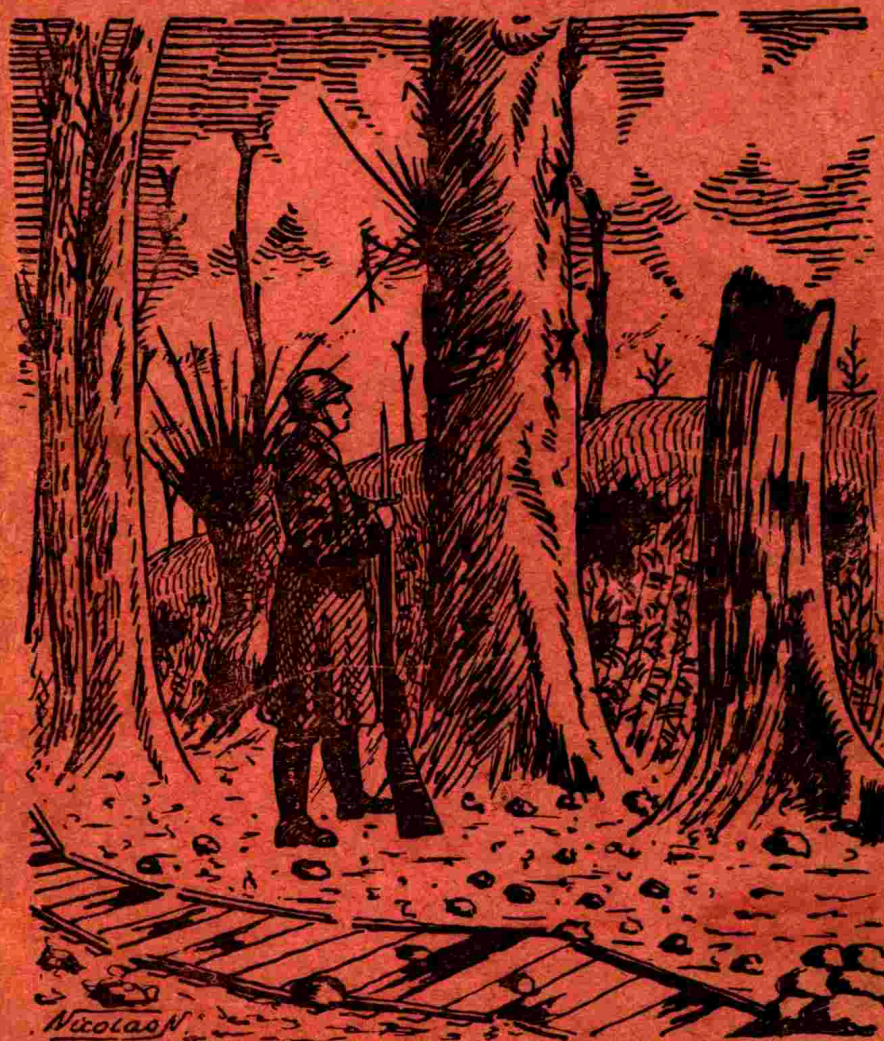
Booklet N° 2.

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PRICE : 1 fr. 75.

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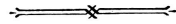
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BELGIAN ARMY

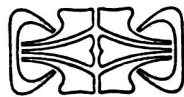
NOTICES

ON

THE OUTLASTING WAR SITES

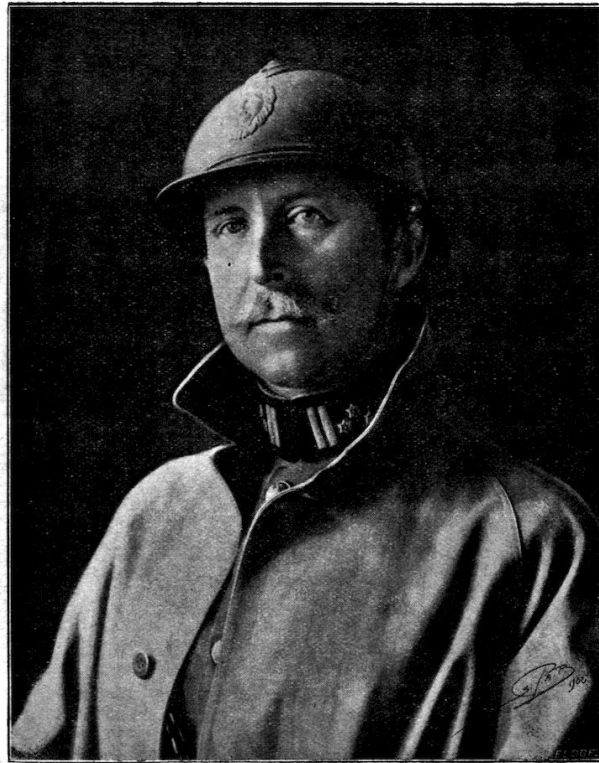


Illustrated by a map scale 1/100.000, four sketches and thirteen photographs
made by the Army Photographic Service.



1923

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H. M. THE KING ALBERT OF BELGIUM.

OFFICIAL LIST OF THE OUTLASTING WAR SITES.

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NOTICES

ON

THE OUTLASTING WAR SITES

1.—German battery “Kaiser Wilhelm II” at Knocke on Sea.

Before going into the description of the war sites along the Belgian sea-coast, it is important to cast a general glance on the defences established there by the Germans.

Admiral Schröder was given the task of the organization of the sea-front. To do so he had at his disposal: the German Marine Army Corps, a coast artillery altogether powerful in number as well as in the caliber of the guns, a flotilla of patrolers, torpedo-boats, destroyers, submarines and a few squadrons of aeroplanes and seaplanes.

In a few months time Belgian coast, thus strongly and thoroughly organized was to be looked upon as a real up to date fortress. The power of the defences was mainly concentrated round Zeebrugge and Ostend,—the two german war outlets of the naval basis Bruges,—also between Lombartzijde and Middelkerke,—where both territorial and seafronts were hinged,—and finally at Knocke and East of that locality, for the protection of the river Schelde’s estuary.

The pivot of the coast defences was to be incumbent on the artillery acting in close cooperation with the land and sea-forces. The artillery was to engage at long range all the allied boats and to keep them under a constant crossfire, while they were endeavouring to proceed towards the coast. For that purpose, about sixty batteries, thirty five of which of the heaviest type were placed either along or at the rear of the sandhills.

In fact, the guns of very high caliber were distributed behind the belt of dunes; their tactical duty was to keep off the coast all boats which would try to carry out long range bombardments. As those batteries could not from their emplacements use direct fire, being unable to see the targets,

observation-posts with good field of view on the sea—for fire registering—were found necessary. Herein lies the reason of the construction of the numerous concrete ones, some of them still remaining hidden along the downs.

As far as the smaller guns are concerned, these were dug in along the dunes and were performing direct fire to prevent against raids, attempts of landing or bottling the harbours.

Against eventual landings, the defences also comprised a series of mine barrages, screens of nettings for submarines, hindering the access of the shore. Redoubts manned by infantry troops were staking out an almost uninterrupted line of trenches which were running along the beach, right up to the Dutch frontiers.

Machine-guns and field guns were utilized for flanking the strand and for anti-aircraft action.

The German defence of the Belgian coast was completed by high sea forces.

The organization of the maritime defences was only seriously taken in hand in 1915. The “Boat-detachment” composed of trawlers, mine sweepers, tow boats and barges, was formed up in February that year. Small types of torpedo-boats and submarines were sent dismounted, and conveyed by railway up to the dock-yards created at Bruges, Ostend, and later on at Hoboken, where those units were mounted. They formed with a certain number of other units which came directly by sea, a flotilla of submarines and one of torpedo-boats. Motor trawlers were on the watch far out in the sea.

In 1916, the naval forces anchored in the Flanders base were considerably increased in number, but it was particularly in the year 1917 that the Germans multiplied their submarines, thus turning the harbours of Ostend and Zeebrugge into real haunts. Shelters were built to protect them against air raids and the numerous bombardments carried out by the British Fleet.

At Zeebrugge, the shelters were established along the mole and in the tidal basins south of the locks and in the Bruges canal.

At Ostend, the flotillas were berthed in the wharfs and the darses. The submarines were sheltered alongside the marine docks.

The year 1917 saw the submarine warfare ruthlessly carried out and the enemy's torpedo-boats raided the British and French coast.

In the early 1918, during the dismal winter nights, the foe undertook several offensive reconnoitrings up to the British Channel. These were to be their last deeds.

Doggedly determined to bring an end to the U boats' boundless crimes, the British Admiralty tackled the plan for the bottling up of the two Belgian harbours. It was thus that were performed the most astounding operations, which took the enemy unaware, pinning him down in Zeebrugge and almost paralysing him in Ostend.



“Kaiser Wilhelm II battery” constitutes one of the typical kind of heavy battery erected by the Germans along the North-Sea.

Armement: Four 12 inch marine guns, firing at 38 kilomètres (23½ miles) a shell weighing more than 400 kilos, needing a charge of 103 kilos.

The tube was 17 meters 25 cm^s long.

Gun crew: 5 officers and 360 other ranks.

Observation-posts: especially in Knocke's Kursaal and on the down 23 near Duinbergen.

Ammunition supply: was done by railway.

Historical account: the battery was armed in July 1916 but did only fire during our Flanders offensive in 1918.

It fired the last time on the 18th October at about 3 p. m. and the next day the battery was taken by our troops.

2.—Germans Guns upon the jetty of Zeebrugge.

We will not study the guns, but we feel compelled to bring back to memory, one of the most striking naval operations of the Great War.

British Raid against Zeebrugge.

Loathing the countless crimes of the foe's submarine warfare, Admiral Sir Jellicoe, the newly promoted First Sea Lord, brought forward a scheme for the bottling up of Zeebrugge and Ostend, the two outlets of the German Naval basis Bruges.

The operations, though of the boldest character, was agreed upon and attempted on April 22^d 1918, eve of S^t Georges' day, patron of England. Admiral Sir Roger Keyes was entrusted with the glorious mission.

Five old Cruisers loaded with ferro-concrete, with on board a crew mainly composed of volunteers were to carry that mission through. Three of these cruisers, namely: H. M. S. *Thetis*, *Intrepid*, and *Iphigenia* were bound for Zeebrugge; H. M. S. *Brilliant* and *Sirius* for Ostend. A flotilla composed of destroyers, submarines, several steam barges and motor trawlers had to cooperate in the action.

The attack against Zeebrugge seeming the more difficult of the two had to be shouldered by the old cruiser H. M. S. *Vindictive* and the two Liverpool carriers *Iris* and *Daffodil*. These units were to undertake a daring diversion in dashing for the pier.

It was 5 o'clock p. m. when the fleet was concentrated at about 63 miles off the coast and from thither directed towards the two goals. While a wind due North East was carrying forward a thick smoke screen produced by fume boats, the fleet sailed forth without raising the enemy's attention.

Unfortunately, at a few cable's lengths from the ports the wind suddenly swerved due South-West, cleaning away the smoke cloud, disclosing at once the "Gallant British Fleet". It was then 11.56 p. m. Like lightnings, all the guns and machine-guns, raised as though by magic power, roared their rapid rounds.

In front of Ostend, the lights guiding the boats towards the coast were hit by shellfire and put out of action. Unable to be driven, the attack failed. H. M. S. *Sirius* and H. M. S. *Brilliant* were sunk at 3 kilomètres East of the harbour's entrance^[1].

¹. The operation against Ostend was successfully carried out during the night of the 9th to 10th May. H. M. S. *Vindictive* managed to place herself athwart in the entrance of the harbour and there

was blown up.

In front of Zeebrugge, in spite of the infernal artillery and machine-gun fire, sweeping the mole, H. M. S. *Vindictive*, under captain A. F. B. Carpenter, helped by the *Daffodil* and *Iris* managed to land his men. That diversion brought the whole fire and the enemy's attention up to the mole, thus clearing the way to the blockships. Machine-gun nests and a part of the enemy's organizations were destroyed or set on fire. Little damage was done, which after all was merely accessory.

During that time, H. M. S. *Thetis* was nearing the channel. She succeeded to cross the mine-barrage but unluckily her propeller got entangled in the nets of the defences, rendering all manœuvres impossible whatever. The commander was then forced to blow her up after that the crew had been taken on board of the trawlers. Her position after all greatly helped the rapid sanding up of the harbour.

H. M. S. *Intrepid* and *Iphigenia* which followed H. M. S. *Thetis* up, overran all the obstacles and managed to enter the canal. They placed themselves athwart in order to block entirely the entrance up. It is then, when freed from their crews that were embarked on board of the trawlers, that their captains exploded charges.

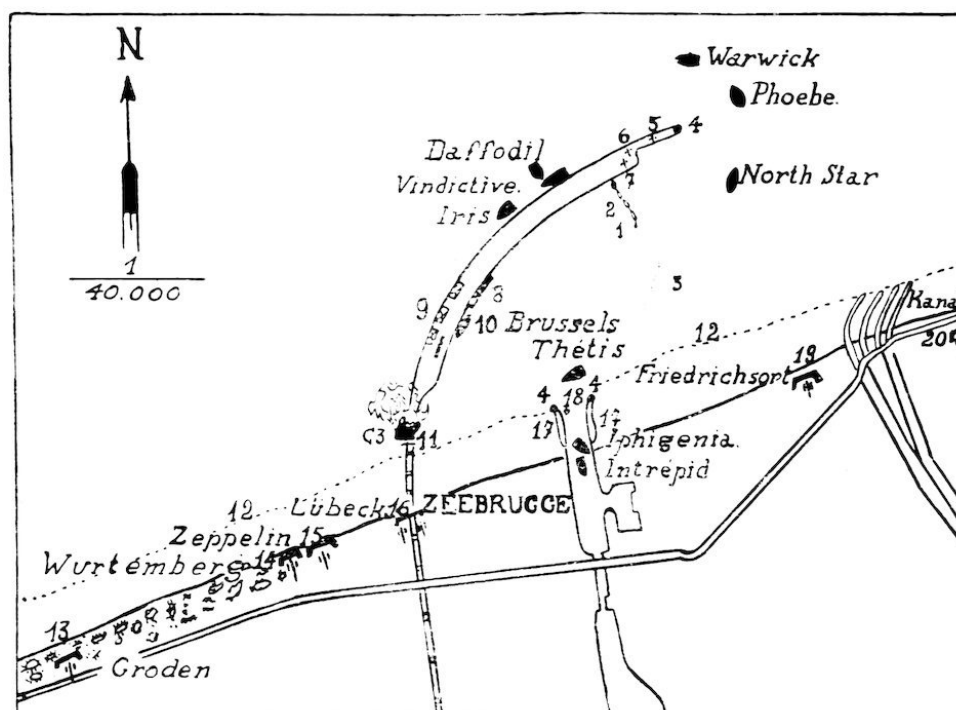
It was while these manœuvres were on, that Lieutenant Richard D. Sandford drove his submarine,—the C₃—, below the bays of the pier and there blew her up, making a breach thirty meters long, thus isolating the jetty from the coast. This last deed was to be the master piece of the gallant expedition. The explosion had been tremendous.

As soon as the three cruisers loaded with concrete had been sunk, H. M. S. *Vindictive* re-embarked her crew and the whole little “British Main” turned back “Homeward-Bound”. The men of the *Vindictive* were then taken on board of the admiral's boat, the *Warwick*.

There is one point which must be kept in mind, that is that during the whole of these operations, the powerful defences, switched on Zeebrugge, were thundering death from every gun, from every rifle and machine-gun, and, under that tornado of fire the battle area was no else but real hell!

The next day, the aerial photographs proved the wonderful results attained by the expedition, results which were far beyond the most optimistical previsions. In regard to this wonderful achievement and the temerity needed to carry it through, the casualties have shown relatively

light. From out of the 1780 officers and other ranks who took part in the raid, 176 were killed, 412 wounded and 49 missing.



The Blocking of Zeebrugge by the British Navy during the night of April 22^d to 23^d 1918.

1.	Rhine barges anchored in line (forming boom).
2.	One pounder quick firing gun (pom-pom).
3.	Nettings of the defence.
4.	Lighthouse.
5.	
6.	Mole batteries.
7.	
8.	Shelter for submarines.
9.	Aeroplanes sheds.
10.	S. S. Brussels.
11.	Breach caused by the explosion of the submarine C3.
12.	Extreme line of the flood.
13.	Groden battery.
14.	Wurtemberg battery.
15.	Zeppelin battery.
16.	Lübeck battery.
17.	Pier.
18.	Channel-entrance.
19.	Friedrichsort battery.
20.	Kanal battery.

As far as the boats losses are concerned, only the destroyer *North Star* and two motor boats went down.

This raid is the most striking instance of military valour and devotion to duty. We feel as though we must emphasize the glorious conduct of the British sailors and the best way is for us to oppose the straight forwardness of the British sailormen to the sly and underhanded methods of the Germans, who only feel apt to sink, without being seen, defenceless boats, thus bringing death on to harmless people.

3.—German battery “Deutschland” at Breedene.

The battery “Deutschland” is situated near the Jacobinessen farm.

Armement: Four 15 inch guns firing at 55 kilometers a shell 2 meters long.

The charge was contained in a brass shell case.

The tube was 17 meters 10 cm. long.

Gun crew: Each gun was attended by 150 men, in other words the whole battery was 8 officers and 600 all ranks strong.

Observation-posts: The main observation-post (concrete) was built in Albert’s Parc; auxiliary posts were connected to it by phones, such was the case for the one of the hotel Belle-View at Wenduyne, and the other called “Fulda” at Mariakerke.

Ammunition supply: was done by railway.

Historical account: The construction of the Deutschland battery was done piece by piece and began in the early part of September 1915.

Belgian labour was requisitioned for that work, with Russian prisoners of war, the hands employed for that battery amounted to seven hundred that toiled months on end for it.

The battery’s activity culminated in 1918, specially in May, going increasingly from the 1st of June up to the 15th, 16th, 17th of October 1918. After the last fire which occurred on the morning of the 17th of October the German disabled the guns and left them few hours later, the battery was then captured by our boys, on their way for victory.

4.—German Battery “Tirpitz” at Ostend.

Armement: Four 12 inch guns, firing at a range of 35 kilometers a shell weighing 375 kilos needing a charge of 103 kilos.

The tube was 12 meters 90 cms long.

Gun crew: 5 officers and 400 other ranks.

Observation-posts: One at Mariakerke on the roof of the asylum, the other in the dunes.

Ammunition supply was also done by railway.

Historical account: The guns of this battery had been ordered to Krupp, by the Belgian Army, in view to complete the armement of fortified position of Antwerp. At the outbreak of the war the German Government kept hold of them and used them for their coast defences in Belgium.

The battery was in position West of Ostend close by Hamilton Farm. The first rounds date from September the 7th 1915. Only two guns opened fire at that time and during one of the firing a barrel of one of them burst causing the death of twelve gunners; that tube was afterwards replaced by another.

On January the 24th 1916, the “Tirpitz” battery fired a hundred shells on the Church of Nieuport and on the old Templers’s Tower, last vestige of the first convent of that order, which dated from the XIIth century. That destruction must have proved very satisfactory to the German commanders, for, in recognition of that gallant deed, iron crosses were awarded to 10 gunners of the battery.

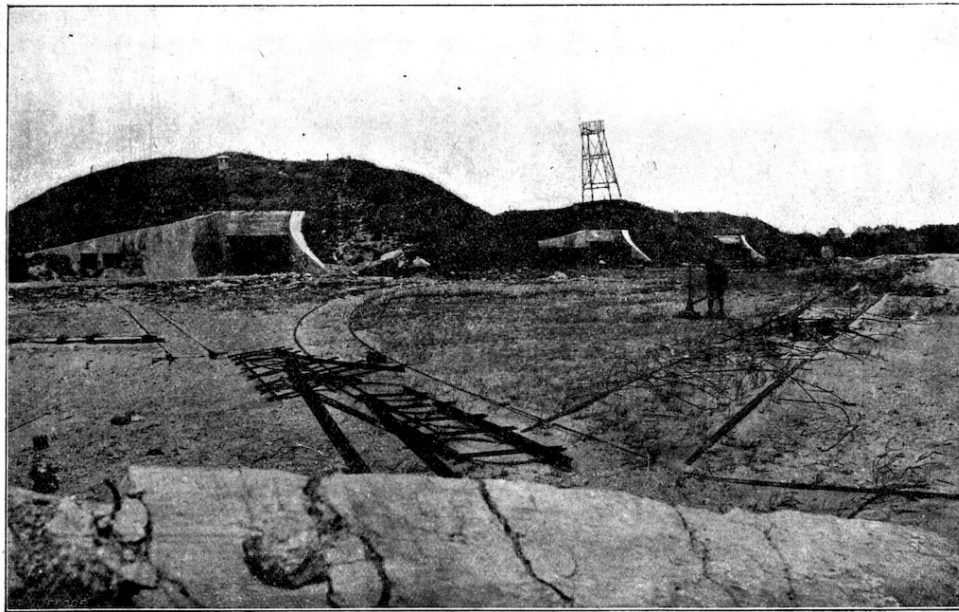
The four guns fired for the first time in battery fire in July the 16th 1916. The allied counter-battery work was fairly active, mainly in 1917 and 1918. The pivot of that counter-battery fire was formed of French 12 inch guns, mounted on railway; these were firing from round Coxyde.

On July 16th 1917 the French gunners were rather successful, several of the guns servants were killed, shelters were destroyed, and the men were scattered. The guns themselves were hit by shell splinters. The top of the gun pits were then strengthened with a bursting layer thick of one meter of concrete, and the battery resumed its action on the 22^d of the same month.

In order to deceive our observers, a dummy battery was erected by the German at about 2 kilometers away from the real emplacement, in the direction of Wilskerke. Two old Belgian mortars of the 1862 type, brought from Liège, and, four dummy guns made of wood were forming the battery. Each time Tirpitz was firing a shot, the dummy was exploding three successive charges, thus giving the impression of four rounds.

Another trick used by the enemy was, that whenever the counter-battery was on, the crew was blowing up huge fougases thus preventing the registering of the fire.

The last fire occurred on the 15th of October 1918, and the battery was then destroyed.



KNOCKE ON SEA.—German Battery Wilhelm II.



NIEUPOORT.—Aerial photo of the Main Redan (August 10th 1918).

5.—German Admiralty Headquarters at Middelkerke.

If the material employed for the coast defences was of the first quality, the German took the same care for the fitting up of the position held by the naval infantry, which disposed of strong and numerous dug-outs, skilfully camouflaged, in other word they formed magnificent battle posts.

The Admiralty Headquarters at Middelkerke is a wonderful display of luxury and it emphasises their taste for comfort.

Nothing was left uncared for; in case of alarm the admiral could easily act in complete quiétude. He had his staff well at hand, his liaisons thoroughly assured and could deliver his orders and instruction with the maximum efficiency.

6.—The “Great Redan” at Nieuport.

From the old fortified position of Nieuport, the part situated North of the harbour solely remained after the dismantling had been decided by the Belgian State, in 1859.

Unproperly called during the war “Great Redan” that work—if one wants to be accurate—is formed of a non reveted horn work which must have belonged to the old fortification of Nieuport rebuilt in 1793, and preceded with a half moon work constructed after 1815.

The whole place, in fact, had to be reconstructed following the Vauban system, with the funds accordingly allotted by the Paris treaty of 1815.

The abandonment of those remains of fortifications since 1859 had evidently reduced them to mere ruins, when the battle of the Yser was fought in 1914. If the “Great Redan” was not utilized during the battle as firing line, at least it afforded a magnificent place of arms, to shelter the reserve troops for the defence of the “Little Bridge-head of Nieuport”.

The latter place also known as the “Bridge-head of Palingbrug” extended itself from the right bank of the channel, at the height of the old lighthouse to the brickwork (Plasschendaele canal) passing by the kilometer 14.500 of the Nieuport Westende road.

It is from the evening of the 20th of October 1914 onward that the defence clung to that position.

To spare his men, Lieutenant General Dossin was contrived to flood the “Groot Noord Nieuwland Polder” up, by letting in the seawater in to the creek of Nieuwendamme, the dikes of which had been previously pierced. This inundation was stretched in the evening of the 21st of October.

After the epic fights at Lombarzyde and Groot Bamburg-Farm, in which heroism was lavishly displayed by our men, during the day and night of the

22nd, the French troops under General Grossetti came at dawn on the 23rd to relieve the Belgian troops in Nieupoort.

They were to resume the offensive movement the Belgian troops had started, but the foe having pierced the line at Saint-Georges and Tervaete, compelled the staff to withdraw the troops from Nieupoort to take position on the bridge-head of Palingbrug, in order to dispose of a maximum of reserve to be arrayed on the threatened front and also to draft the counter-attacks which were more and more urging.

On the evening of the 26th, Colonel Claudon, commanding the French troops at Palingbrug, judging his contingent too weak to hold on that position, retired on the left bank of the Channel, in doing so he gave up the bridge-head, the Great Redan, the five bridges and the locks, in one word that retreat meant the abandonment of the key of the whole hydrographic system of the region.

Fortunately, the enemy not only worn out but much more concerned with the center of his front of attack, did not venture to keep in touch with the troops at Nieupoort and failed to notice the leaving of the right bank of the river Yser, of which he might have so easily drawn advantage. The German, perhaps still believing in the existence of the fortress of Nieupoort, did not attack.

Up to the 3^d of November 1914 the Palingbrug was left abandoned. Though, it is during that period of time that the inundation was stretched. A first attempt took place on the morning of the 27th of October, but was a failure, it is only at 5 a. m. on the 28th that we managed to open and keep it so during the incoming tide, the old lock of Furnes.

The inroad of water through that lock having been reckoned insufficient, the Belgian G.H.Q. decided to make use of the Noordvaart lock, but the latter was since the evening of the 26th right in "No man's land", position which rendered the operation most dangerous.

Under the protection of 40 cyclists carabiniers who had to cross over in walking on the Furnes lock gates (the bridge having been blown up, by order of Colonel Claudon after the retreat of the 26th), Captain Umé, of the Royal Engineers successfully managed to open the locks of Noordvaart. The following nights the operations were renewed and gradually the sheet of water rose and rose. Awestruck by that mystery, the enemy, fortunately realised it but too late.

At last, on the 3^d of November, while the Yser battle had proved a victory, all along the Belgian line, reconnaissances were carried out in front of the advanced posts.

On November the 4th, detachment of the 2^d Army Division occupied again the bridge-head of Palingbrug and the Redan, which we pledge our word was never tread on by German heels.

A few time afterwards an offensive movement took place and was undertaken by the Franco-Belgian troops, that operation forced the enemy to give up the channel North of the “Geleïde”. The front was then fixed on a position baptized “The Main bridge-head of Nieuport” on a line parallel to the channel and at about 600 meters East of the latter, running round the Western side of Lombartzyde and prolonging itself almost parallel to Plasschendaele canal up to the Boterdijk.

That front never knew any alterations till July 1917.

The 10th of July 1917, at about 8 o'clock p. m., after a regular bombardment of more than 10 hours duration, all along the Nieuport sector, the enemy rushed the positions held, only since a few days, by the British Infantry. The fight lasted the whole night long and after the most bloody hand to hand fights, the attackers succeeded to enter the British trenches between the beach and the Geleïde and throwing the occupants in the channel, those who swam across escaped from death or capture.

From up the 11 July onward the Nieuport front was running along the channel right up to Geleïde river, where it was hinged to the primitive front, which determined attacks had successfully brought to its original point.

Later the “Redan” and its surrounding area were subjected to almost daily bombardments, which soon gave them a bloody fame.

The powder-mill of the old work, thanks to the superimposed vaults, which were forming its ceiling, managed to resist to all kind of German shells, which made it deserve the nickname of *Rubber house*. It was occupied during the operations both as battle headquarters and as advanced dressing station.

In March 1918, the Belgian front had to be stretched out, in order to relieve allied divisions. To avoid the weakening of our resistance, our front having been thus considerably lengthened and the occupation having become very thin, the G. H. Q. decided to stretch a further inundation which allowed to gain up several outposts.

At Nieuport, the Redan became the front line. It was hooked North by the “huitrière” (oyster-pond), fronting the West bank of the channel, and South at “Dupuis and de Luc” trench.

Those three points d’appui formed an important point of resistance: they were covering the locks. They were garrisoned by a battalion; its duty was to hold at all costs and it did it.

At last, the Belgian offensive was launched from up the southern part of our front on the 28th of September 1918. North of Dixmude our troops remained momentarily waiting and the position of Nieuport had still to suffer severe bombardments. But the last occupants of the Redan stood them up lightly, only anxiously waiting their turn to rush victoriously over the parapet. The kick off was given on the 17th of October and the very same day they were able to admire with a legitimate pride the magnificent enemy artillery, which had made them suffer so much and that the Germans had left them, the guns still loaded.

7.—Karnak battery at Oost-Dunkerke.

English battery composed of two 9.2 inches, guns. That battery was situated at about 1 kilometer East of Oost-Dunkerke and at 200 meters South of Oost-Dunkerke bath and Nieuport bath road.

Its interest lies in the reason of its having been constructed underneath the great dunes, from that emplacement the battery drew the three fold advantages in regard to camouflage, protection and mainly in creating great difficulties to the German counter-battery; indeed the latter was deprived of any aiming point whatever, and the shell craters were rapidly leveled up by the sand.

Karnak battery, which was manned by British gunners had been placed under the Orders of the O. C. of the Nieuport sector, who utilized it for momentous counter-battery and destruction fires.

8.—Levelcrossing guard shelter at Ramscappelle with machine-gun-pit.

Ramscappelle was the only point West of the Nieuport-Dixmude railway line that ever was trod on by the invader. After the taking of St-Georges on October 24th 1914, the foe in order to widen his success rushed on the 26th for the Noordvaart and compelled our troops after a night of fierce struggle to withdraw on the railway track, on which they clung without much difficulty up to the 29th of October.

During the evening of the 29th, two attempts of the enemy against the railway line facing Ramscappelle failed. The 30th, at 4.45 a. m. a new trial was again pinned down. And finally round 5.30 a. m. after a terrific artillery preparation, a last and more powerful attack than the previous ones, forced the resistance at a point South of the halt of Ramscappelle, the enemy linked himself on the railway line which he now enfilades and thus proceeding northward, reached the village.

The 5th and 6th line Regiments, which had battled with the finest determination, withdrew and took a strong position at the Koolhofbrug and Jockveld farm from whither they managed to prevent the enemy to emerge from out the village, thus stemming the rush for good and all.

Lieutenant General Dossin, in command of the 2^d Army Division, ordered the counter-strike to be organized at once. Accordingly at the beginning of the afternoon a force composed of four French Battalions and five Belgian ones plus a machine-gun company, and, with in support two Belgian and two French battalions, went slowly forward, encircled the village altogether northward, westward and southward. When that move had been completed, the assault was launched; it was then 7 o'clock p. m.

The group of houses on the southern side of the wind mill and the wind mill itself were carried out at the first jump, thanks to the fighting spirit of the men and also to the efficient artillery fire of N° 26th Belgian Field Battery, which, in spite of a hurricane of machine-gun bullets had been brought as far forward as the Pelican bridge.

The fighting ground being of a very close nature permitted but a very slow progression of the wings. But nothing daunted, the attack however reached the nearer outskirts of the village, bar the eastern side of the brook, called Ramscappelleleed excepted.

The night was spent in carrying out violent musketry fire, and to goad the enemy several reconnaissances were pushed in the village while a section of a French and Belgian bridging company was erecting a foot bridge on the Ramscappelleleed. The artillery kept hammering the enemy's defences into ruins.

At dawn of the 31th of October, the german resistance weakened and a general attack carries the village up bringing in one jump the assaulting troops right up the railway line, scattering the remaining defenders and pushing them back toward the river Yser.

The german fled, leaving their dead and wounded behind them, they also abandoned in the inundation the two famous "Minenwerfer", which only seven days ago had annihilated a whole Belgian battalion, which was defending the Yser crossing at the Union Bridge.

During the whole war, the Nieuport-Dixmude railway line formed in the "Ramscappelle sector", the main line of resistance. When the water had retired a little, the sector was guarded by two main-guards i. e. Rijkenhoek and Beverdijk, particularly famous as kick off points for the numerous attacks and raids of our troops against the Violette and Terstille farms.

That line offered numerous and well constructed shelters affording to our men relatively comfortable dwellings. Here and there, at places offering good field of fire or permitting to sweep main-traffic passages concrete machine pits (such as the one at the station) were built. In the hut of the railway guard an artillery observation-post was also constructed.

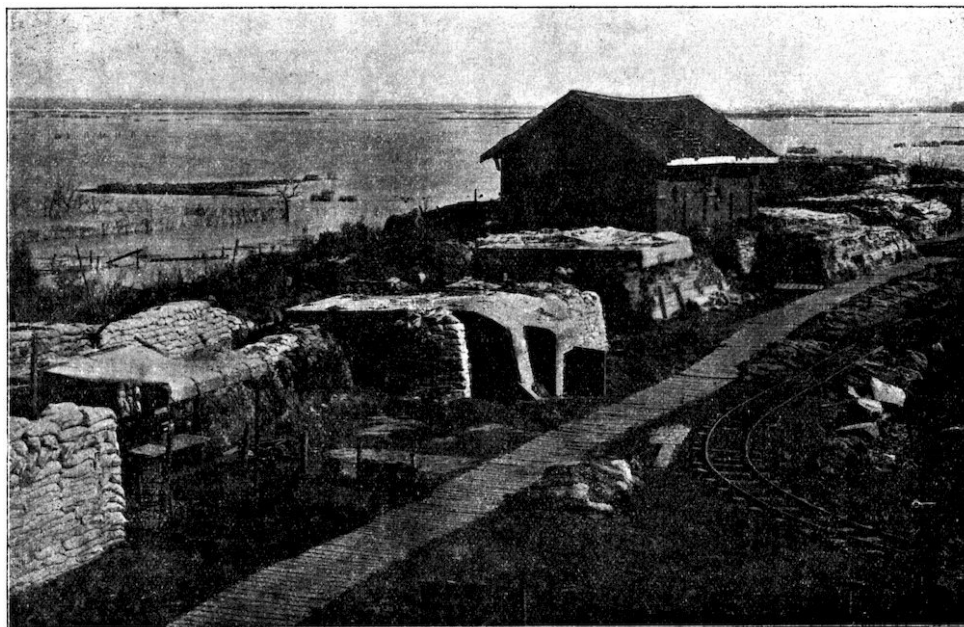
**9.—Machine-gun shelter facing the Pervyse
railway station.**

10.—Observation-post at the Pervyse railway station.

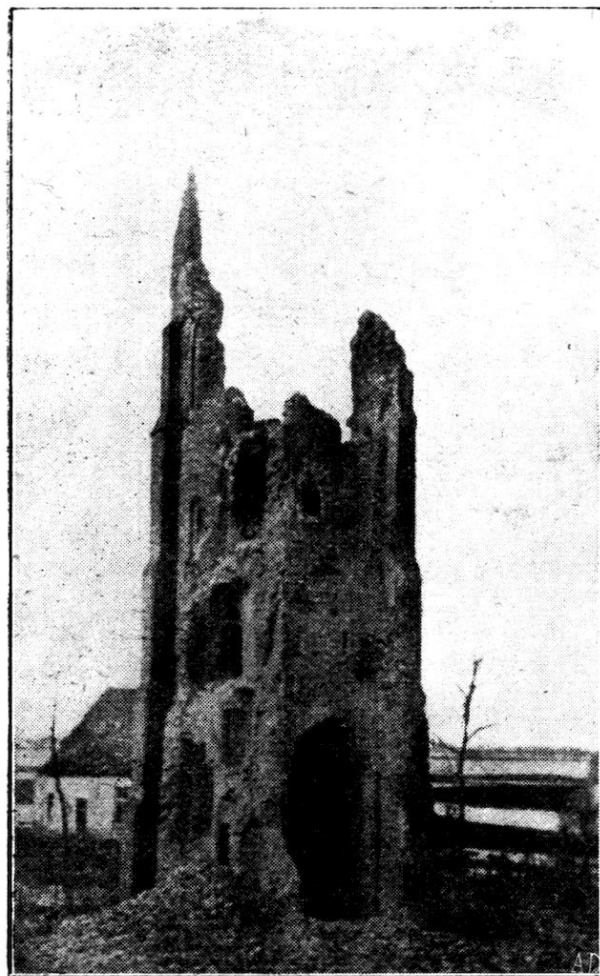
From up the 26th of October 1914, date at which our troops were compelled to leave the Beverdijk, the Dixmude railway track outlined in front of Pervyse our first front line.

On the 30th of October meanwhile the foe was rushing for Ramscappelle he hurled detachments against the Pervyse station. That attack miserably failed under the violent rifle firing of the 1st Battalion of the 12th line Regiment which had been swiftly reinforced by few sections of the 2^d Bat.

The assailants fled seeking refuge in the houses bordering the Schoore road opposite the railway station, where they were made prisoner in the course of the day. The rest managed to retire back to their former position but had to fight their way through the inundation in order to rally their line.



PERVYSE.—The inundation facing the railway station (September 1916).



OULD-STUYVEKENSKERKE.—The Tower (November 1914).



OULD-STUYVEKENSKERKE.—The Tower (February 1917).

The above assault was to be the only one the first line of Pervyse ever had to grapple with.

The main-guard of Schilderbrug with its advanced posts, (one outlook post on the road and two sentry posts on the water with the intermediate ones) gave the troops a sufficient security to allow the men, in spite of the rafale fires which from time to time poured upon the line, to say: "It is fine in Pervyse".

The line was organized since the early days of its occupation, then was gradually improved to become during the last years of war a model of stabilized trench warfare area.

Even the station itself, where an artillery observation-post had been constructed, was wedged in a powerful stronghold whose solid concrete shelters for machine-guns were forming the bastions.

One of the above mentioned machine-gun pits, that of the south eastern angle may still be seen and will give a thorough idea of the organization.

The observation-post of the railway station, one of the main O. P. s. of the Belgian front, had a vast field of view and was provided with visual apparatus of the highest precision.

It was connected in 1917, by means of two telephone wires with alternative courses, to Dunkirk signalling post and that, in order to warn the city of the firing intended for her by the Leugenboom gun.

The report of the monster, perceived at Pervyse was at once communicated to Dunkirk where the receiving station was to alert the town by means of the powerful steam-whistles or other such alarm signals.

11.—Battalion commander's Headquarters at Km. 4.400 of the Nieuport-Dixmude railway line.

That concrete dug-out served as battle Headquarters to the major commanding the Oud-Stuyvekenskerke subsector. It was of that type adopted for such shelters prompted along the railway line.

These emplacements were generally constructed in the years 1916 and 1917 to take the place of the far less resisting ones whose walls as well as roofings were formed by beams and logs in juxtaposition. The roof had been rendered waterproof by means of tarred board, while a more or less thick layer of bags filled with concrete rendered them safe against small shells.

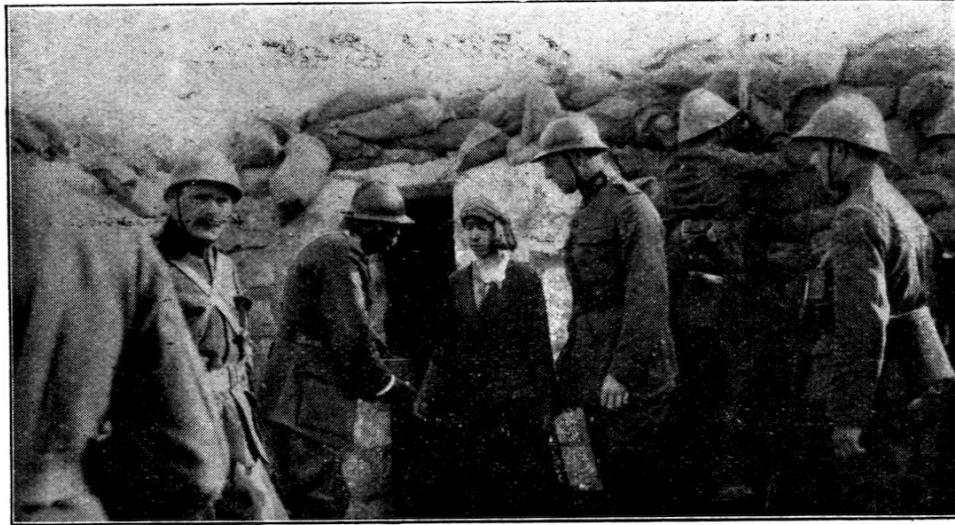
These which replaced them, some of which are still remaining such that of kilom. 4.400, were very well conceived. They often contained several different rooms, the number of which were varying according the need of the sector: major's orderly room, major's and adjutant's lodging, visual signalling and very-light posts, telephone central, etc....

12.—The base of the tower of Oud-Stuyvekenskerke.

The old tower of Oud-Stuyvekenskerke has not been able to resist to the amount of projectiles poured upon it by the Germans, throughout the whole campaign. Its emplacement however, and the concrete bloc which has taken its place are interesting as marking the extreme advance of the enemy in the region, it also brings back to memory the terrific bombardments and fights which that corner of Flanders witnessed.



DIXMUDE.—Aerial photo (Mai 26th 1917).



DIXMUDE.—Their Majesties King and Queen at the “Death trench”. (June 1st 1917).



DIXMUDE.—Their Majesties King and Queen at the Riderswork. (June 1st 1917).

The Queen examining private J. Vermeire's helmet, which had just been pierced by a German bullet.

At the end of the Yser battle, after the 29th of October 1914, Oud-Stuyvekenskerke was only occupied for a few days by weak German detachments, whilst our line of defence had been brought back upon the Nieuport-Dixmude railway line and rejoining the Yser at the kilometer 16 by a line running through Roode-Poort farm and the houses of the Burg.

Then the flood forced the foe to withdraw up to the bank of the river.

On the 3rd of November 1914, the Belgian G. H. Q. ordered to push forward reconnaitring parties all along our army front; advanced posts were then placed which, little by little were multiplied untill they formed a complete defence line of advanced guards, acting as outposts screen to the whole defence scheme. The main-guards were all on duty beyond the inundations, the mean of access to the main-guards being long duck boards placed on threstle stuck in the soil. The one leading to Oud-Stuyvekerskerke was particularly dangerous because the Germans had aimed a fixed rifle on it, which was sweeping its whole length. The losses there sustained have been very heavy, mainly when relieves were on. To cut the casualties down the 4th line Regiment erected concrete shields against bullets and shell splinters.

The main-guard of Oud-Stuyvekerskerke was protecting the left flank of the organization of the Dixmude sector and that by keeping under its fire the whole of the ground stretching itself in front of their advanced posts. Besides, the hamlet which was situated on a little knoll, was thus affording great advantages for the creation of observation-posts.

In connection with this “War-Site” there is a name which is closely associated with every details of its life. Known as the “Burgomaster of Oud-Stuyvekerskerke”, R. Father Martial Lekeux, Artillery Commander, spent the first years of the war in the tower, then when latter tumbled down, he moved in the gable front of a farm where he organized a remarkable observation-post. The name of Martial Lekeux deserves to be mentioned here, because his dogged determination and pluck, unidentified themselves with that main-guard of Oud-Stuyvekerskerke.

Three momentous German posts, were facing it, i. e. the farms n° 1, “den Toren and Van de Woude”, which owed many a tragic days to the keen eyes of the Belgian observer.

For four years on end of trench warfare the main-guard of Oud-Stuyvekerskerke held fast. It held under storms of iron, it held against assailants who, at renewed attempts endeavoured to overrun it. These different rushes, the one of March 1918 against our cyclist carabinieri and the 1st foot jagers as well as that of June of the same year against the 22nd line regiment have disclosed the stubborn energy and enthusiastic courage

which moved our men of 1918, classing them amongst the best fighting elements of the great allied armies.

13.—Death Trench and the “Cavalier” field work.

When the battle of the Yser was over, our first front line was running along the river in front of Dixmude in a direction due North-West up to the kilometer 16. There the river Yser, makes a sudden bend and our front was leaving the river side to prolonge itself westward, leaning on the Roode-Poort farm thus joining the Nieuport-Dixmude railway line.

That particular point of kilometer n° 16, which ought to have been on the early days of stabilized warfare, a stronghold of our defensive scheme, struck our high command, as being rather weak. The decision was then taken to strengthen it.

A line of main-guards already covered the Belgian positions from Nieuport up to Oud-Stuyvekenskerke, when General Jacquet decided, in order to cover himself at the kilometer n° 16, to prolonge that line by adding to it an element, the advanced posts of which would be placed along the river Reigersvliet and that right up to its mouth.

To carry that mission through it was thought necessary to rush the petrol tanks, the mystery of which, more than their power had already given to the sector a fair renown.

similar work was on, which, in less than a fortnights time reduced to few yards the distance separating the Belgian saphead from the enemy's.

On the 27th of May 1915, during the relieve, and taking the advantage of a pitch dark night and protected by a violent bombardment, a group of Germans jumped in our trench placing a machine-gun section in it. The enfilading fire of those guns caused heavy casualties to the 9th line regiment which delivered a counter-attack.

After useless efforts, the only alternative left was to push actively forward the organization of the remaining portion of the trench so as to render it able to resist, notwithstanding the achievement of the previous object, it is to say the strengthening of the Yser salient at kilometer 16.

From time to time, the enemy tried to attack the trench but each time was repulsed by spontaneous counter-strokes. The enormous casualties suffered, either by the bombardments or by the numerous raids, carried out by the enemy, against the trench, made it deserve the name of: "Death Trench". (Boyau de la Mort.)

In September 1915, the more urgent works of the Death Trench were nearly finished and could easily suffice to the defence of the left bank of the river at kilometer n° 16. The attention of the engineers was then driven on to the construction of the "Cavalier", work which was to complete the above mentioned defence, by securing it against all attempts of the enemy to cross the river.

The characteristic features of the "Cavalier" comes from the working condition it had to be submitted to, it is to say, to combine the defence as to fit or better to match in the most perfect way to the one of the "Death trench" thus forming a center of the highest possible resistance.

The "Cavalier" in itself presents two different and parallel lines, the first one on the level with the ground, to serve the purpose of round way and communication line, the second, above level thus dominating the whole region. The latter trench is the firing one, the overlooking position of which permitting to carry out enfilading and plunging fires upon the two banks of the river Yser as well as in the Death Trench itself, and on the enemy's organization round kilometer n° 16.

The dead angles of that position were under machine-gun fire and later, automatic rifles were placed at the entrance of the Death Trench, and also in the one connecting it with the "Cavalier".

The building up of the “Cavalier” was long and cost to our sappers and infantrymen many a toilsome days and many a casualties. Seeing those provoking works, the German indeed did not remain inactive, they frequently ruined our works with their artillery and minenwerfers, inflicting to our troops awful losses.

The close of 1915 marked the end of the grounding of the accessory defences. The emplacements for trench mortars, machine-guns pits were rising little by little, the dug-out for the officer in Command of the “Cavalier” sector, was gradually coming to shape, and the shelters were rising from out the soil.

It was then decided to reduce the occupation of the “Death Trench”.

On October 11th 1915, the bank of the Yser was blown up by a mine at about 275 meters in front of kilometer 16, thus opening a gap 6 or 8 meters in length, which connected the Yser to the flooded area. The Northern portion of the trench was filled up and then abandoned.

Three bombing teams, garrisoned by day time the thus shortened line.

Our men had become first class bomb throwers and feeling themselves well shouldered by the Van Deuren mortars (Belgian Stokes Guns) were full of confidence and never feared their opponents.

In 1916 the organization of the “Cavalier” completes itself and becomes a real redoubt. The two flights of the work is provided with offensive and defensive weapons, as well as with liaison material of the most diverse nature. Concrete shelters for the men have taken the place of those built with logs, which so often were bombed to ruins by the enemy. A post of visual signalling was placed so as to maintain a constant contact with the commander of the sector.

May 1916 was to be a tragic month for the kilometer 16 sector.

From up the 2nd on to the 22nd, the German switched on the “Death Trench” a fire of the most terrific power, and hurling troops forward they managed to get a foot-hold in our position, but nothing daunted, a counter-attack winged them at once back, by dint of grenades fights and sharp hand to hand struggles.... The enemy fled, he had not even had time to take his dead and wounded back with him.

In July 1916, an artillery observation-post was established at the “Cavalier”. The camouflage section came and erected there a strong steel

cabin, loopholed towards the enemy side, and also provided with a periscope. A telephone wire was connecting that post to the Divisional Artillery Commander.

But the month of May with its hard and bloody days the men had to contend with, were not to be forgotten, and a keen wish for vengeance was nursed by every one.

Was the No "One" enemy trench not presenting itself to us in a similar way as our "Death Trench" to him? In fact, we were on the bridge-head on the right bank. The attack and destruction of that line was decided.

On July 18th 1916, after that several reconnaissances had made during the preceding nights, and thorough destruction fire switched on to the trench, a detachment of n° 4 company of the IVth Bat. of the 2nd line Regiment, under the command of Lieutenants Loyse and Desenfans stormed it. The object of the raid was not to remain there, but the duty of the raiding-party was to "clean the place up" and keep it free of Germans a sufficient length of time to blow all the concrete shelters up, to render them uninhabitable. The "cleaning up" was thoroughly done, but unfortunately Lieutenant Loyse having been dangerously wounded, could not give the signal which was to start the blowing of the charges, that sapper sergeant Billiet had placed, after having himself taken an ample share in the first part of the show.

This raid is recorded as an example of the kind. All the dead and wounded of the party were brought back to our lines.

The enthusiasm was at its highest, the confidence kindled, the regiment avenged.

The sector was calm for a good while.

The 17th of October 1916, the German, roused once again, opened on our line, at kilometer 16, the most powerful bombardment, foreboding a new attack. But our gunners were on the watch, they directed at once a counter-bombardment so violently efficient that it must have taken out from the enemy's mind the slightest wish to jump out of his haunts.

Ten days later, the 2^d line regiment decided to do away with the "One" enemy trench, for good and all. From up the 27th on to the 31st of October detachment raided by night the accursed trench, they undertook the destruction of the shelters, turning the whole of No "One" line into real havoc.

In the course of the years 1917 and 1918, the life at the kilometer 16 quietened down, the intervals between the bombardments and mortar duals lengthened, and were replaced by intermittent artillery and hand grenades fights.

The “Cavalier and Death Trench” received then their final improvements. The first observation cabin having been demolished by gun fire, on April the 4th 1917, a new one in concrete took its place, the upper trench became a platform, the liaison and signal post provided with ground telegraphy. The automatic rifles and bomb throwers multiplied.

The Death Trench was provided with an alternative straight communication line. A light wooden railway track was layed, to enable transport and evacuation by means of the small trucks. Numerous “concrete-brick” shelters were created.

Finally the head of the trench was turned into a deathtrap, surrounded by wolf’s holes and barbed wires, that point was only manned by day time by snipers sheltered in a small concrete sentry box.

The trap was separated from the death trench by a monolithic concrete dug-out of a rather peculiar shape. That shelter was fitted with a heavy steel door, and loopholed to enable hand grenade throwing and automatic rifle’s firing. A vibrating connected the little redoubt with the Commander of the “Cavalier”.

In case that the enemy managed to enter the trap or to reach our trench, the garrison of the fortlet was to shut itself up in it and resist from within during a length of time sufficient to be relieved by a counter-attack delivered by the “Cavalier” which had been alerted by the buzzer.

During the Franco-British offensive of October 1917 numerous fires were carried out by our artillery to prepare the eventual cooperation of the Belgian forces. That artillery action brought on to us energetic retaliations which did a lot of damages to the line at Roode-Poort.

The numerous raids of our troops in the German lines proved the efficiency of our fire, which had reduced the enemy’s trenches to mere ruins.

When the 1917 offensive was stopped the life resumed its normal and dull course; the 5th infantry division was set at work to repair the damages and restore to our positions their former power.

Our attack of September 1918 had a repercussion upon the whole sector overlooked by the Cavalier.

The first battle had brought the Belgian Army on the Clercken ridge. The intention to hinge the new front to the old one including the Dixmude town, induced the 5th line Regiment to get hold of Trench “One”, “111”, as well as of the first work North of Dixmude. And this was to be the only alteration brought on the front round kilometer 16.

From the 15th to the 17th of October, under the victorious onrush of the second battle, the front was split up from Nieuport to Dixmude and the Germans were compelled to a hurried retreat.

The front of the Yser was definitively cleared, the Rider and the Death Trench had ended their glorious mission.

It is important to note the powerful organizations of the enemy, facing the “Death Trench”, notably the enormous concrete of German sap-heads on the leftbank of the Yser, with their iron-plated loopholes and firing ranges, overlooking all the surrounding districts.

The Rider is a work of the greatest interest. It may be considered as a small museum concerning the trench warfare. In the minimum space it utilized in a most judicious way all defensive and offensive implement such as accessory defences and all kinds of liaison systems, which were coordinated to bring the highest efficiency.

It was also the witness of the magnificent and sustained stoicism on the part numerous Belgian soldiers who succeeded each other to defend it.

The Death Trench is a sacred spot, sacred by the acts of courage and heroism that were accomplished there, and sacred by the blood that was shed here, it is the tomb of hundreds of brave heroes.

**14.—Company commander's post near the
Yserdam, at Dixmude, in front of the canal of
Handzaeme (leftbank).**

16.—Concrete dug-out south of the railway bridge at Dixmude (left bank).

These two shelters mark out the portion of the Belgian front which suffered the most by German bombardment with trench-mortars shells and bombs.

During the dreadful days of May 1916, our first line, facing Dixmude was subjected to awful firing; the embankment of the Yser, behind which our men were sheltered, was overthrown, the shelters broken down, the relief posts destroyed. All the work of the trenches which had taken eighteen months of patient toil to erect was annihilated in a few days and transformed into a horrible chaos. Hundreds of brave soldiers were torn to pieces by the bursting of German trench mortar shells, the effects of which were so terrible that in falling they dug craters of 10 meters diameter, thus smashing up the strongest shelters, and crushing and burying under the ruins all those who had taken refuge there. After the storm calmed down (and it was only calmed when our mortars arrived, affording us then the opportunity to juggle with those of the adversary), the Belgian soldiers with their habitual tenacity, undertook to rebuild their defensive works. Night and day, they worked patiently and obstinately on, and in the face of the enemy which was watching them from the opposite side of the bank, managed ruins out of the ruins that were accumulated there, to erect new lines of defence, stronger and better established than the first. They were composed, besides firing parapets for infantrymen, of numerous shelters for snipers and machine-gunners, rest and waiting shelters, relief posts, fighting battle posts for unit commanders, etc.... Earth, wood, iron, concrete, all were put together and used to constitute a formidable entrenched line, which was held till the end of the war.

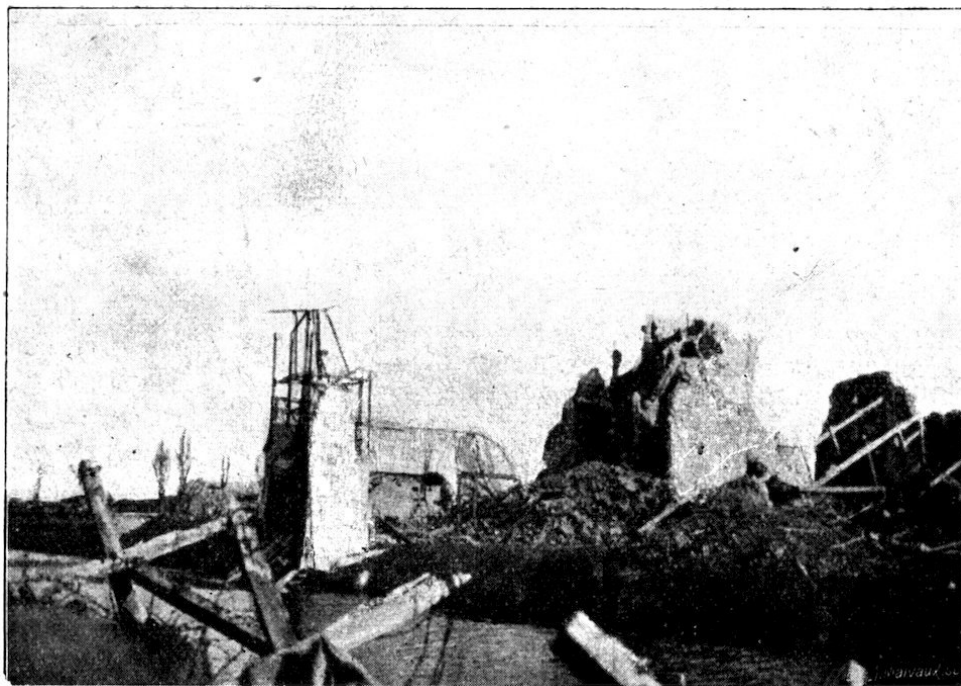
From amongst these numerous shelters, two have been preserved: the first at the South of the Bridge-rail of Dixmude, is situated in the centre of the bend formed by the Yser in front of the town. The second was used as a fighting post for the commander of the company entrusted to defend the portion of the embankment, situated in front of the Handzaeme Canal. That particular point was specially momentous and to be watched, because it meant there to forbid the inroad in our lines of the Germans troops, which, under the cover of the Handzaeme canal banks, could, mounted on little boats berthed at Dixmude, try a landing on the West bank of the river Yser.

15.—The Flour-Mill of Dixmude.

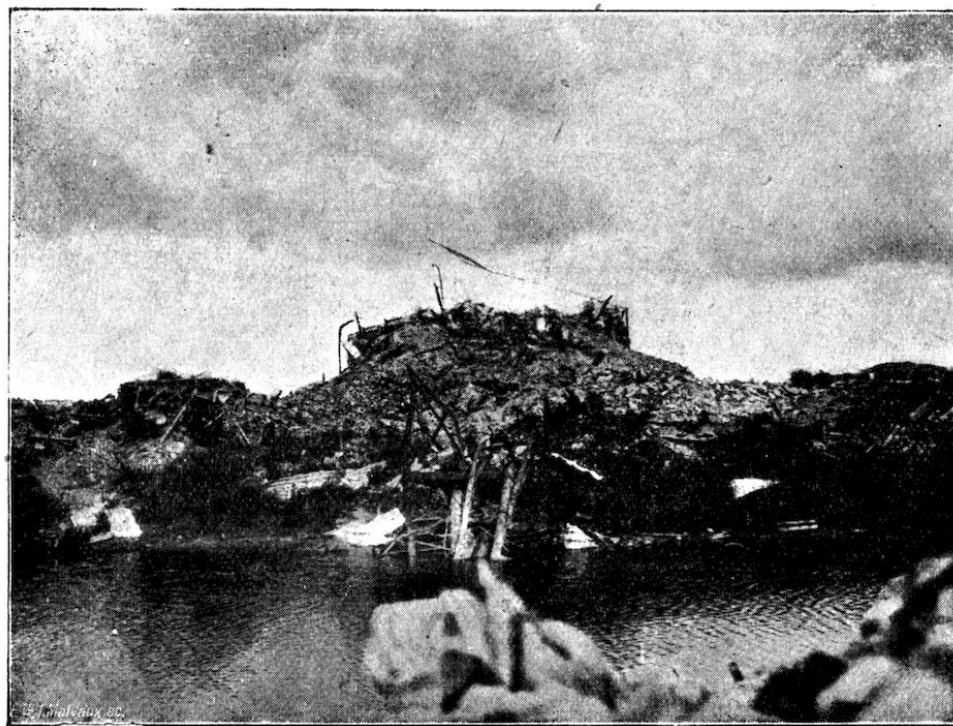
How can one recall the battle of Dixmude without having before one's eyes the vision of the flour-mill rising far above the ruins of the little Flemish town? One saw it in spite of oneself; in fact nearly always one felt its presence. During the four years of trench warfare it was the vigilant eye watch of the enemy. An eye with a look of fire and iron. An eye which had the command over powerful artillery, over numerous minenwerfers, and even over simple snipers who coldly struck down the imprudent and foolhardy ones who ventured to brave it, very often without being aware of it.

At the beginning of the war, a legend ran that the massif construction of the corn-mill was built by the Germans. The authorised opinion of E. Hosten in his book entitled *the Agony of Dixmude* gives the lie to this assertion in the following terms: "It is quite evident at the present day that the platform of the huge cube of cement which formed the corn-mill of Dixmude was not erected on the shore of the Yser, solely to receive heavy German artillery which from that matchless observatory could have overlooked and swept-away all the surroundings".

During the tragic days of the battle of the Yser (from the 17th to the 31st of October 1914) the bridge-head, created round Dixmude was preserved in spite of the many furious assaults of the enemy. It was the witness each day, each hour even, of incredible and superhuman tenacity and endurance on the part of the Belgian and French troops. Those brave soldiers were commanded by energetic, resolute and iron willed chiefs, whose fame has long classed them among the most accomplished men of the war. Let us suffice to mention the celebrated and famous names of Ronarch, Meiser and Jacques.



DIXMUDE.—The flour-mill (La minoterie) in 1916.



DIXMUDE. The flour-mill (La minoterie) in 1917.

The corn-mill, in this position acted the double part of observatory and shelter for the defensive reserves. An observer connected with Colonel De Vleeschouwer, who was in command of the Belgian artillery in front of Dixmude, could, while placed on the platform of the building, direct the firing on all telling points, such as batteries of the enemy in action, troops on the march, preparations for attacks, etc....

The enemy did not allow our artillery such an advantage for long; the corn-mill was partly taken by the German batteries, which took great pleasure in directing blazing fires on that colossal building. The observer was forced to abandon his post, but nevertheless not without the satisfaction of having registered to the best advantage and conditions the first fires of our artillery.

The corn-mill, from that time, was simply utilized as the nest for the reserves of the bridge-head. A company, to which a platoon was sometimes added, composed its garrison.



The night of the 25th to the 26th of October 1914 was marked, in the resistance of Dixmude, by a unique and singular incident.

In the evening of the 25th, groups of Germans had managed to creep into the intervening spaces of the trenches, situated between the railway line of Zarren and the road leading to Eessen, trenches which were guarded by troops physically exhausted, whose lines were considerably weakened by ten days of cruel and outrageous fighting. These groups of enemies formed themselves up again inside our lines. The night was as black as ink, and unfortunately the guns on the road of Eessen were jammed.

As soon as Lieutenant Simon of the 12th line was informed of the incident by one of his men, he immediately directed an intensive fire on the Germans, putting a great number out of the field. The others reformed on the road. They were about three hundred. Headed by the Major and accompanied by an enervating music of fifes, they penetrated in the town, firing on all lited points, such as fighting posts, shelters for troops, relief posts, killing and capturing on their passage all small and isolated groups of French and Belgian soldiers who were taken prisoners and forced to march in front to serve as shields.

Thanks to this infamous trick the German column arrived without incident as far as the bridge road. The latter was crossed by the allied soldiers followed up by the Germans, the Major included. The machine-gunners of the bridge only perceived their mistake when a hundred pick helmets had already passed over. They then opened a muzzel to muzzel fire on the rest of the column which went whirling over and was scattered in the town, leaving numerous dead and wounded on the pavement.

In the meanwhile the troops of the bridge-head were living the most thrilling moments of the battle. Nevertheless though much unnerved, they were maintained at their post, thanks to the marvelous calm and heroic energy of the officers who examined and rectified the occupation of the trenches.

And then, what an unutterable relief to the troops and their chiefs when they heard the guns firing on the bridge road proclaiming loudly that the line of the Yser still held good and that it had not been taken unawares!

Till dawn, the front of the bridge-head had to face at the same time, the positions of the enemy, and the town. It was not necessary. The Germans who had crossed the bridge, marched on at random. At a little distance at the East of the halt at Caeskerke, they soon ran up against a company of the 12th of the line in reserve. (The C. P. of the admiral was composed of a group of cyclist carabinieri re-enforced by their runners). Without fighting the enemy detachment turned South across the fields, and fell, without knowing, on our batteries and would have surprised them without help when fortunately the detachment was taken between the fires of several groups of French and Belgian soldiers and was encircled without difficulty. Not quick enough though, to prevent the said detachment of committing the most abominable crime: the massacre without mercy and without distinction of their prisoners.

Taken prisoners in their turn, the Germans could have been judged according to the regulations and an avalanche of shot would have sufficed to have stretched them out. But we were struggling for the Right; brought before Admiral Ronarch, he decided to have executed militarily the Germans who had shown themselves the most cruel in the massacre; three amongst these, recognized by the Belgian doctor Van der Ghinst, who had been taken prisoner during the night, and had escaped by miracle, were shot on the spot, the others were sent to the back.

As for the part of the German column which had not been able to cross the bridge, this was taken under the fires of the guns, and was, as we have already said, dispersed in all directions, endeavouring to seek refuge in the houses at Dixmude. The reserve garrisoned in the flour mill, awoken by the noise of the fighting and being at once acquainted with the situation, remained in place, ready to intervene.

The Germans, who tempted to take refuge in the corn-mill were shot down without ceremony, and at daylight patrols were sent in the town to search the houses, and arrest all those who were hidden there. The nightmare was ended, and confidence revived more than ever.

This trick of the Germans, which might have figured in their war annals, as a glorious page, simply lengthened the list of their crimes. On the other hand, it set off more than ever the admirable qualities of the French and Belgian armies: the confidence of the troops in their chiefs, their character and above all their generosity perhaps somewhat exaggerated when addressed to individuals deformed by a barbarous "Kultur".

The action of the bridge-head ended with the battle of the Yser, the 1st of November 1914; anyhow for reasons purely moral, it was still kept there. The occupying troops were reduced.

The defensive artillery was also reduced in too large proportions owing to the reason that a great quantity of pieces had been disabled, moreover the munitions were deficient. Many empty ammunition limbers could not be replenished, already for several days the wants surpassed the means of supply.

The days of the 9th and 10th of November 1914 marked out the agony of Dixmude which began by a general bombardment of great violence, to which our twenty guns of 7c5, with only the aid of a few heavy french guns, could but attempt a retaliation.

The 3^d battalion of the 1st line regiment and two battalions of Singalese kept the bridge-head.

The 10th, about 7 o'clock, a first German assault failed before our lines, to the great astonishment of the enemy who was convinced that he had annihilated all our defences.

His plan of attack had to be completely altered. The XXIIth army corps of reserve was charged with this mission. Three convergent columns took the

South and East sectors as though in pincers. The artillery carried on an infernal fire, casting and sowing death in the trenches, in the town and on all accessible roads to our reserves.

The South sector resisted, the East one also, but unfortunately a portion of the trench, situated between the railway line and the road, and only guarded by the dead and wounded could no longer keep back the enemy who rushed the position and took it back handed. Then began a most terrific fight, the memory of which makes the ancients shudder. It was a serie of hand to hand fights, individual fights with the bayonet in the streets, in the houses, in the trenches, leaving on the ground at every step, the blood of the vanquisher as well as the vanquished.

Unfortunately the admiral disposes of no reserves at hand. He cannot untrim the bank of the Yser which will have to face the attack if continued, and endeavour to bar the crossing of the river.

And that is why under the pressure of numbers and after several hours of bloody struggle, the defenders of the bridge-head were forced to concentrate themselves in the corn-mill and in the trench preceding it. During several hours it is a resistance, where the resolute and determined courage of a few men, held the head to a numerous enemy which was struck down in heaps.

In the meantime, the bridging company had placed a foot bridge across the Yser at the western side of the corn-mill thus permitting the last defenders of Dixmude to cross the river, sheltered from the front fires of the infantry.

All our men re-entered the corn-mill. The order for the general retreat arrived. It was four o'clock p. m.

With heavy hearts, those brave troops who had fought like lions and who were determined to the last sacrifice leave their fortress of one day cast a last look on the smoking ruins of the town, on the corn-mill, which in its turn begins to burn (the fire was set during the defence by a french soldier), send a last and pious thought to all the gallant heroes who have just bravely fallen for their country, and the river is crossed.

Twenty-two officers and a large number of soldiers were missing at the roll call on the left bank.

The German attack attempts again the passage of the Yser, but it is annihilated. The artillery thunders, all the time, but the infantry holds, and will hold till the end.

Thus were the last spasms of the battle of the Yser, and the trench warfare begins.



The Germans occupied Dixmude and the corn-mill. Our first line was staked out on the West of the Yser. From one end to the other, positions were organized, fortified and armed according to the constant progress of the science of the new war, which transformed the sectors into real fortresses, whose smallest corners hid instruments of death.

The corn-mill did not escape German organization. Strong, it was already, but it was rendered undestroyable. The walls were used as lock ups for tons of concrete in the midst of which were disposed a series of shelters and posts of observation, which had nothing to fear even from the most enormous projectiles.

The corn-mill was a source of great suffering to our troops, not only by the watchmen, but by the minenwerfers that it sheltered. Our artillery made many desperate attempts to attack it. It only managed to round its cubic forms and to pulverize certain points of its bulk, but that was all.



During the Franco-British offensive from August to October 1917, our staff thought, at a certain moment to be able to extend on our front the progression of the Allies. It was at the time of the long artillery preparations. Our batteries, re-enforced by numerous guns of heavy calibre of the allied armies, executed a systematic hammering on the enemy's front, which after a few days enabled us to believe that the works of the enemy had been absolutely and thoroughly annihilated.

It was decided to ascertain and see the state of the upheaval. Consequently raids were undertaken on all the beaten front. They were a great success, except at the flour-mill.

On the nights of the 28th to 29th of October, on the 3^d and 4th of November 1917, detachments of the 5th and 6th of the line regiment crossed the Yser with magnificent spirit. The South and North trenches of the flour-mill were

cleaned out without great difficulty, but when the detailed group attacked the flour-mill, there was a reaction, and a painful one which cost the life to many a brave man, a reaction which proved once more, the power of inactive and inert substance against which courage is nothing. Through their invisible loop holes and under the thick armour of their shelters immersed in concrete, the few occupants of the flour-mill soon overpowered the will and determination of our troops, who were forced to retreat taking away with them their dead and wounded.

The Franco-British offensive could not be continued for several reasons, and our army resumed the life of the trenches which still lasted another year.

At last there was the liberating offensive.

The rapid progress of our troops forced the enemy to abandon Dixmude. Our soldiers entered there the 29th of September 1918 and settled there till the 15th of October, date of the second rush forward.

The town was nothing but a heap of ruins and the flour-mill a grey shapeless mass, which will perpetuate the remembrance of this long war and the numerous heroes fallen there under its blows.

17.—Albert and Elisabeth Redoubts.

18.—The Joconde's dwelling.

19.—Battalion commander's Headquarters (all between kilom. 19 and 20 of Yser river, left bank).

The fighting posts and shelters established after the battle of the Yser, in the ruins of the small buildings along the embankment, saw little by little their walls relined with a strong interior casing of concrete, and their lost roofs, replaced by thick concrete layers also. The house of the Joconde (so called, because of the good old proprietress, Mieke Bœuf, who during long weeks of trench warfare still occupied it and who became quite legendary with our soldiers), served as a lodging to the Commander of the company at the bridge-head, till a better appropriated shelter was built. It was occupied after, by the men of the Royal engineers, who were charged to keep in good order, the foot bridges giving access to the bridge-head.

The next house to the one of the Joconde's served as C. P. to the major on guard.

After the organization of the bridge-head (see notice n° 20), an allround plan fortifying the sector was elaborated. They foresaw the construction of little forts or redoubts with a distance of 600 meters between each and utilizing the embankment as a parapet and the Yser as obstacle.

It was with the redoubts Albert and Elisabeth that they began. They were finished in December 1915. The reason of their existence, was to protect the bridge-head against enfilading fire; but that was not the only part they played. These two redoubts completed and formed with the part of the embankment which bound them together a kind of curtain which had to hold good, whatever happened.

The system and assemblage of fires which shot out from the numerous loop holes and "embrasures" of their shelters for machine-guns and rifles gave them an enormous capacity of resistance.

The redoubts Albert and Elisabeth were the work of the engineers of 2^d army division.

20.—The Bridge-Head at kilometer 19.500 (Right Bank).

When the Belgian front was stabilized (November 1914), it was in part covered by floods, before which our posts soon became powerful main-guards.

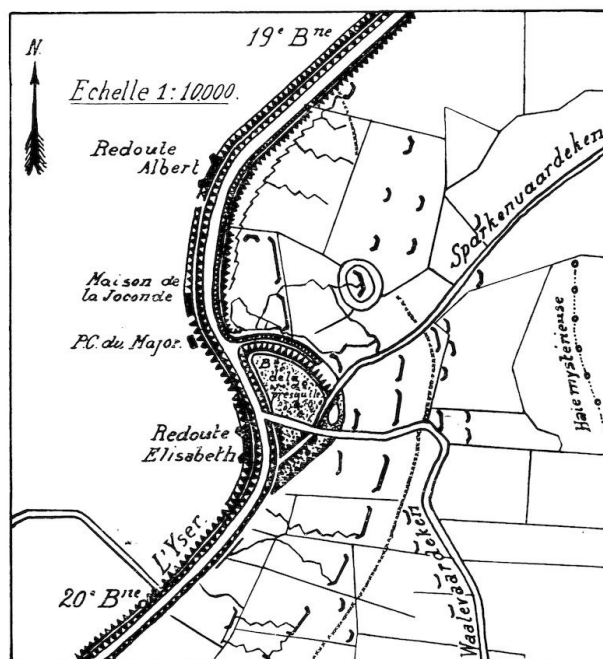
Two well distinctive floods had been spread; the first during the battle of the Yser, was extended between the river and the railway line Nieuport-Dixmude having the paved road Oostkerke kilometer 16 of the Yser as Southern limit; the second, subsequent to the fall of Dixmude was created at the request of the French troops from the 14th of November 1914. All the land situated at the East of the Yser, between the Houtensluisvaart and the road embankment of Knocke to Drie Grachten was flooded (this was realised, thanks to the great difference of water level of the two river-banks. The one on the right bank being inferior to the one on the left).

Between the kilometer 16 of the Yser and Houtensluisvaart the obstacle of water did not exist. The enemy, at Dixmude occupied the right bank of the Yser, which alone separated the adversary lines. At the South of the railway line of Dixmude to Zarren, the German positions followed a course almost parallel to the road of Woumen, comprising the strongly organized points such as the cemetery of Dixmude, the Castle of kilometer 19 and several farms. Our troops continued to follow the left bank of the river.

After the victory of the Yser, the constant idea of our staff was to reconquer the most ground possible. The Belgian army built on all practicable spots; posts of various degrees of importance, and this principle was applied to the sector of Nieucappelle on a very large scale.

It was decided to establish on the right bank of the Yser, at the South of Dixmude, towards kilometer 19, to the close contact of the enemy a bridge-

head which would be afterwards widened, in order to create a starting position to permit our army to take an offensive. It was Major Panhuys who was charged with this perilous operation, with a group composed of his own battalion (the 1st battalion of the 2^d foot jagers), re-enforced with a company of machine-gunners and a company of cyclists. It was important to take the enemy unawares. All was put in action to that end, each one having his definite mission to accomplish. During the night of the 21st to the 22^d of December 1914, a night cold and dark, the group crossed the river in two places and managed to instal itself on a position uniting the little wood of the peninsula of kilometer 19.500 with a bend to the North, facing the cemetery of Dixmude. The enemy being taken by surprise, could not till dawn offer an efficient resistance: but already our troops had organized the ground and maintained their positions in spite of firing, counter-attacks and severe bombardments.



Bridge-head of kilometer 19.500 of the river Yser
in June 1915.

The heroic group, who had performed the operation with such valour and spirit, was mentioned in despatches by decision of the H. M. the King.

It was of the utmost importance to strengthen the occupation, but there could be no question of working by day, the enemy holding the watch and

sway over the land, and especially over the knoll of Woumen (castle of kilometer 19). So our troops were kept to the task without respite.

Afterwards the extension of the bridge-head to the South, for months saw added to the companies on guard, picket companies and detachments of pioneers, nightly erecting parapets and communication trenches, building shelters, casting footbridges over muddy ground, covering the positions with wire netting work, regulating the current of the waters at Sparken and Waalevaardeken by locks and dams, multiplying and rebuilding the footbridges on the river etc., in a word executing the thousand and one labours required by an advanced position to render it strong and powerful, durable if not comfortable and give to the troops of the principal resisting position real and positive security.

Then, arose the question of progressing towards the East and towards the North. The works of extension were commenced, but it was soon realised what a great effort and incessant sacrifice such an enterprise would demand, that about Mai 1915 the bridge-head was brought back to its former line. During the course of the war, the evolution of fighting methods altered and likewise the mission of the advanced positions and the effective forces of the garrisons which held them. For this reason, when the bridge-head of kilometer 19.500 was created, and which had to resist to the utmost, it required more than one battalion to guard it; and in 1918, a few posts of section or squad sufficed, the mission of the advanced ones having simply become at this place, for watching purposes in case of a defensive, or kick off in the case of an offensive.

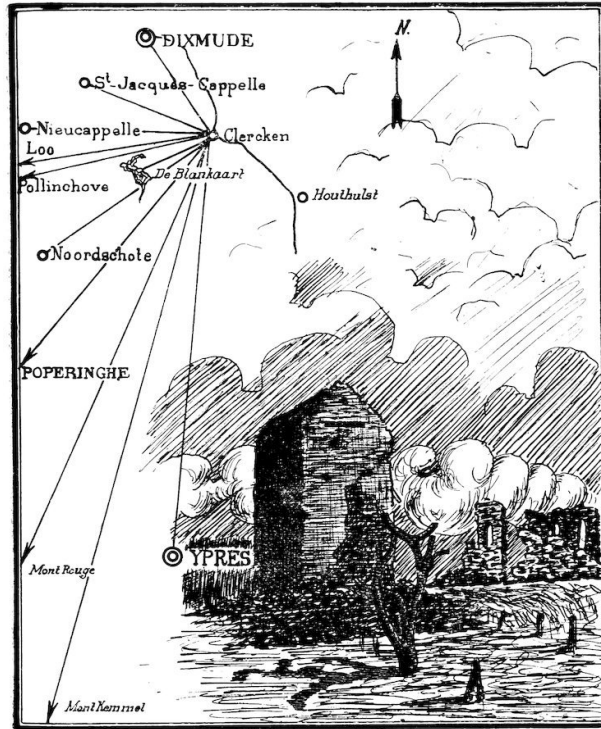
To give one an exact idea of the enormous effort that the bridge-head of the kilometer 19 cost, one needed to see the development and extension it had taken in May 1915 and be equally penetrated with the idea, that all the work had been done at the price of heavy losses, although it had been done by night, under the bullets and shrapnells, in bad weather and often with reduced means. This bridge-head contributed greatly to maintain an offensive spirit in the minds of the infantrymen, it served also as a base to many patrols towards the enemy's organizations and notably to a famous raid on the castle of kilometer 19 on the night of the 28th to the 29th of October 1917, which was a brilliant success, led by Captain Dendal, who brought back materials and prisoners.

Several times the Germans tried to rush the bridge-head of kilometer 19, but without any result whatever.

And then during the offensive of September 1918, it served as a starting trench to the troops of the Belgian 4th division, for the victorious assault which ended by the liberation of Dixmude.

21.—Observation-post near the Church of Clercken.

Clercken Ridge was very precious to the enemy to whom it gave the opportunity to establish a lot of natural observation-posts which had not the vulnerability of the confined kite balloons and which assured more stability to the observation. Many of these posts were destroyed during the war, especially by the destructive fires which preceded the great offensive in Flanders on the 28th of September 1918. Others, such as the mill of Clercken, are already rebuilt, so offer no longer any historical interest.



German observation-post near the church of Clercken.

Sketch showing the directions of the villages seen from this observation-post.

However the one which is situated near the church of Clercken, and still exists in the same state as when abandoned by the Germans (see sketch), shows how easily the enemy could see into our lines, in spite of all the efforts made by the Belgian Army to counteract their observations, such as: diverse dissimulations, plantations of all kinds, artificial masks in linen, sandbags, reeds and straw, etc....

22.—“Grand-Père” concrete dug-out.

23.—“Castel Britannia”.

24.—Hoekske.

The southern part of the Belgian front may be classed as one of the most agitated sectors of the Western front. The short communications of the press which announced in their brief laconic style: “Bombing actions at het Sas and at Steenstraat; duel of artillery in the region of Noordschote”, said nothing of the horror of certain days of guard where the blood marked the ground of trenches, a hundred times turned over and as many times reestablished and always defended by our heroical troops. Drie Grachten, le Passeur, Steenstraat, Merckem, all these names resound, like as many bugle calls proclaiming the heroism of our soldiers and the glory of our arms.

It was in July-October 1917 that the Franco-British offensive gave us back, in that region, a corner of Belgian land. A few Belgian units participated on the 27th of October to the last assault which drove the enemy back beyond Luyghem, Kippe, Aschoop and reached, on the right, the outskirts of Houthulst forest. The effort had to be followed up, our troops had to extend to the North of Dixmude, the progression of the Allies; our artillery preparation was ended, the Belgian army only waited for the signal!

But a run of unfavourable circumstances: the russian defection, the Caporetto incidents and the continual rain obliged the allies’ chief staff to suspend the offensive. One had to be resigned and wait, but it was a great deception to the Belgian soldier.

The 11th of November 1917, the 4th army division relieved a French division at Merckem. The state of the field after the battle, is depicted in the following extract from the order of the division commander dated the 14th of November. “In order to avoid, during the relieves, the sinking of the men in the excavations which are hollowed out all over the track, it is advised to

gather the men in groups of five, holding one to one another with a rope and thus lending each other mutual help.”

Nineteen hundred and seventeen was, in fact, the year of offensives with long artillery preparations, which transformed the battle fields into masterpieces of devastation. The soil ploughed up by thousands of projectiles formed a vast field of hollows, filled with water by the autumn rains. Nothing else was seen in this desolate landscape but a few cut down trunks of trees and the monstrous concretes of the Germans, which were sometimes demolished and overturned.

However, it was absolutely necessary to remain on the chaotic ground. The positions had to be established strong enough to repulse the counter-attacks. At first it was only a system of shell holes surrounded by blocks of concrete which had been deserted by the enemy. It was a dreadful hard winter for the 4th army division. When the engineers and infantrymen at the price of terrible labour, had repaired and rebuilt the roads and tracks which facilitated and rendered possible the relieves, the rational and defensive organization of the sector was undertaken. Successive lines showed themselves, and were bound between by intermediate lines and a well organized plan of defence was able to be applied.

The “Grand-Père” (Grand-father) concrete dug-out, the remains of which have been preserved, was one of the posts best known among of the advanced positions of Merckem. It formed a rather prominent salient which was always a temptation to the enemy and provoked him to many sudden attacks, generally preceded by violent artillery fires demolishing all the surroundings.

The 4th army division managed to repulse two attempts and that at two days’ interval: one on the night 26–27 and the other 28–29 of November 1917. They were more like trials on the part of the enemy to stake out our advanced positions.

During the occupation of the sector by the 3^d army division, the raids became real attacks to reconquer the “Grand-father”. The 15th of February 1918, the enemy was thrown back in his own lines; but on the 7th of March, he managed to take a footing and bring machine-guns in the concrete shelter, from where our counter-attacks drove him out on the evening of the 8th.

It was decided then, to rectify the advanced line by suppressing the salient of the grand-father, and also the one, constituted by three little posts of Aschoop, which also was subjected to the enemy's fires.

The last german raid on the "Grand-father" was on the 27th of March 1918, which hastened the decision, taken on the 29th of the same month, to abandon after destruction the salients of the Grand-father and Aschoop.

The "Grand-father" was again occupied by our troops the 9th of September 1918 after the taking of the german position of Kwaebeek brook. A centre of resistance was established there and was occupied till the offensive of the 28th of September 1918.

The name of *Castel Britannia* was given to the place occupied by the enemy's batteries which oppressed up till 1917 our positions of the sector of Steenstraat. Thick concrete masses protected them. They served under the Belgian occupation as observation-posts and battle posts.

The cross road of *Hoekske* is situated at the crossing of Steenstraat to Dixmude road with the road of Merckem. It marks nearly the centre of the subsector which bears its name, and is celebrated by the numerous bombardments it has been subjected to. Heavy pieces of german artillery have been sunk in its vicinity.

These three sites are destined to perpetuate the remembrance of the defence of Merckem sector, organized by the 4th army division at the price of the greatest difficulties during the winter of 1917, and brilliantly defended by the 3^d army division in April 1918, and the gallant fields of action of the 1st army division at the time preceding the offensive of the 28th of September. These sites will remain in that region, the witnesses of the *battle of Merckem*, which was fought the 17th of April 1918 in the neighbourhood of Kippe near Langemark, and where the 3^d army division, under general Jacques, and the 4th army division, under general Michel, were covered with glory.

The Germans, who were in immediate contact with the 3^d army division at Kippe, made a sudden and abrupt irruption in the lines of this division and advanced up to the front of the Merckem and Hoekske trenches, where they were stopped.

Brilliant and heroical counter-attacks cleverly upheld by the artillery, drove them back disabled in their positions.

On the side of the 4th army division, the enemy, who, before approaching the front had to descend the slope at the North-East-bank of the Broenbeek and although vigorously welcomed by infantry and artillery fires, managed to push through a corner between the main-guards of Champaubert and Montmirail, whose wings were turned over to form a hook. Held in that way, the efforts of the Germans to open the breach further were vain. Crushed by violent musketry fires and the precise firing of the artillery, the enemy could not hold the positions reached and had to retire.

The battle of Merckem which had not procured to the Germans one atom of land, nor advantage, cost them many dead and wounded, eight hundred prisoners and the loss of numerous material, which was left in the hands of the 3^d army division. The order of Leopold was granted to the 9th regiment of the line and to the 1st jagers.

The inscription of “Merckem” on the regimental Colours of the 3^d army division, and on those of the 13th and 19th of the line (4th army division) and also on the shields of the guns, rewarded the bravery of the troops who won the battle.

As regards the moral point of view, the victory of the 17th of April in which our regiments had overthrown whole divisions of enemies, revealed to the General Staff, the offensive worth and power of our army and gave to it the full due, of its conscientiousness and strength and the ardent desire to go forward.

From the 17th of April, our soldiers at Merckem felt themselves masters of the sector. Patrols and audacious raids were undertaken, sometimes on Kloostermolen, sometimes on the trenches of the Kwaebeek position or on the Little-son and on Italy, Portugal and Epernon farms.

The numerous prisoners brought back from these expeditions supplied our Staff with informations, which were the more interesting because, at that time, the allied armies had begun to drive back the enemy from the French front.

At last, on the 9th of September, at dawn, a brilliant attack was executed without great loss by the 3^d line regiment. The position of Kwaebeek, entirely taken, was organized, and, when a few days later, the enemy who had recovered, attempted with the aid of great reinforcement to drive back

our troops in their former lines, the success was of short duration, for the enemy had to let go.

It was from the position of Kwaebeek, that the 1st Infantry division, started the 28th of September 1918 to the signal for the great liberating offensive.

25.—The big german gun of Leugenboom at Couckelaere near Moere.

Not having succeeded, in spite of their brutal effort and the use of asphyxiating gas, which till then had never been made use of, to pierce the front at Steenstraat, in April 1915, the Germans who had foreseen every thing, began to bombard Dunkirk, this permitted to their press to hide the check, to cry out loudly “Victory, our artillery is bombarding Dunkirk”.

A marine gun of 380 mm. installed in a public house called “In het Predikboom” (kilometer 12th, road Dixmude-Poelcappelle) had just started, to execute its first shot. That was on the 26th of April 1915.

A powerful counter-battery action was soon organized and proved a success. Twice the gun was disabled, the first time for a period of forty two days and the second time for forty eight. The 9th of August 1915 registered its last shot.

Nevertheless the counter-battery maintained its firing in order to prevent the Germans rebuilding the place and arming it.

In October 1916, an extraordinary activity was shown at the former emplacement of Predikboom. Numerous and deliberate firings were executed by the counter-batteries; and one might well ask if this German activity was not a new dodge. Another place, in fact was being built at Leugenboom (3200 meters to the North of Couckelaere).

The emplacement of Leugenboom was noted for the first time the 7th of May 1917 by Captain Jaumotte while making one of his aerial reconnoitrings. He took a photograph of it, which clearly showed the advanced state of the works, the switch line, grafted on a point to a normal gauge, thus forming the junction at Eerneghem, to the state railway line Ostend-Thourout.

Without a doubt the firing on Dunkirk was going to begin again.

The Belgian artillery staff, started at once a plan of action against that urgent threat. The said staff obtained of the 36th French army corps, which was operating on the Belgian front the aid of two guns of A. L. V. F. (*artillerie lourde sur voie ferrée*, i. e. Heavy railway battery) two magnificent naval guns of 305 (12 inch.).

These two pieces will be the soul of the counter-battery, they will be upheld in their action by a special group of numerous heavy batteries which will make opposition on all german batteries opening fire on the two heavy guns.

The plan was prepared, but to realise it, important and preliminary works had to be executed, which took five days after Captain Jaumotte's reconnoitring.

These works consisted thus: first of all, the building of firing emplacements for the heavy artillery; establishing many telephone connections, needed since the creation of the special group, connections which had to perform not only the centralisation of the command, but also a perfect understanding between the director of the firing, the batteries and the observation-posts and the cross registering section, as well as the creation of antennas to receive the messages of aerial observations.

The railway battalion, pushed on after three days of splendid and extraordinary efforts, the works sufficiently far to render the point of Eggewaertscappelle capable of bearing the firing of the heavy guns. The group of telegraphists and telephonists accomplished at the same time, grand and important works of liaison, which altogether constituted the tool of the firing director.

A firing program was elaborated, a program which led the action on Leugenboom and on the Tirpitz battery (see site n° 4) at the same time. The firing on the Tirpitz was assured by two heavy guns of 305 in position on the point of Coxyde-Bains.

The 13th of May, the two heavy guns of 305 were brought to the place of firing which had been chosen—the switch-point of Eggewaertscappelle—and a nice clear day was waited to open action. That beautiful day was longed for right up to the 20th of May 1917.

The execution of the genuine program was preceded by an independent firing directed on the German observation-post installed in the belfry of Eessen, with a 240 (10 inch.) gun in position at the East of Burg Molen, upheld by the special group. The tower was partially demolished.

About 11 o'clock, the heavy guns of 305 of Eggewaertscappelle fired their first shot on Leugenboom, while the gun of Burg Molen continued its demolishing and blinding work on the enemy's observation-post. A little while after the guns of Coxyde-Bains entered in action in their turn against Tirpitz battery. The observation of these firings were both terrestrial and aerial.

The firing program was continued the following days when the weather was favourable for observation.

On the 25th of May, an aerial photograph of Leugenboom position was taken. It did not disclose the least damage to the concrete block, but its clearness sufficiently noted the gun carriage not yet armed, in the centre of the honeycomb which formed the platform.

In order to parry, as might be the case, to a more accurate enemy counter-battery, the railway battalion built or layed out sucessively several sites for heavy artillery firing. It is so, that two sites on the switch point of Eggewaertscappelle, a third at the station of Moerhoek and a fourth on the point of Isenberghe, served as reserve, and were occupied in turns.

The Leugenboom heavy gun entered in action the 27th of June 1917. Between 5 and 10 o'clock, it bombarded Malo-on-sea and Dunkirk. This first action made numerous victims. The shells were of 380 mm.

One shell, amongst others, the first, it is thought, fell on the Casino of Malo, where the general staff of the XVth British army corps was established: it made twenty four victims, eleven dead and thirteen wounded.

In July 1917, there were several bombardments to be noted on different objectives: Furnes, Dunkirk, Coxyde, Forthem and Alveringhem.

The bombardments of Dunkirk, threatening to become very frequent, alarmed the authorities, and it was decided from the 19th of July 1917 to create two direct telephone lines at different courses which would join Dunkirk to the Pervyse railway station observation-post, which was particularly well situated.

The starting shots of Leugenboom, heard at the railway station at Pervyse, were in that way instantly communicated to Dunkirk, where the reception posts gave the alert to the town by powerful horns and other alarm engines, thus permitting the population to take refuge in the concrete shelters specially built for that purpose.

In spite of the well studied counter-battery, the Leugenboom gun still continued firing. The lulls, which lasted often long time, gave the hope that a positive result had been obtained. Then after a lapse of one and sometimes two months, the rage of the Germans revived and Dunkirk was again subjected to further attacks.

In 1918, bombardments were very frequent. At certain times, they became even daily, but Dunkirk was not always the objective. In May and notably in June, the firing of Leugenboom was directed on Klein-Leysele and the 27th of September 1918 on Bergues.

The offensive of Flanders, at last lights up. But the enraged Germans will hold on till the last minute.

It is only on the 16th of October at 20 minutes to three that the heavy cannon of Leugenboom is for ever silenced. In its last spasms of agony it dealt terrible blows to the localities situated behind the front of attack.

At last on the 17th of October the monster of Leugenboom belongs to us. Our troops neared it, and, passing by it, threw a slightly haughty look, but certainly encouraged by their grand trophy. Pressed by our soldiers, the Germans had hastily attempted to put their cannon out of action. It was loaded and levelled horizontally, and so it remains to the present day. In that position they hoped that the projectile would touch the concrete mass before being entirely shot out of the tube, and that its bursting would blow up the flight. But their anticipations were not realised; the projectile, instead of being stopped by the mass of concrete, passed through it, making a breach and burst about 800 meters further.

It was a Krupp marine gun of 380 mm. (15 inch), type 1914, n° 154, of a total length of 17 m. 13 placed on a gun carriage, formed by two formidable tanks, tap rooted in the centre of a concrete pit. This pit has a special shape because, of the conditions the constructors imposed themselves to give it a field of fire of 157°, the axis of which passes by Dunkirk.

The total weight of the piece is 77630 kilos.

The breech has an outer diameter of one meter, the manœuvre is electrical but there exists handles for hand manœuvring. The artillery men were entirely protected by a cabin joined to the gun carriage, built in strong sheet of iron of a thickness of about 50 mm.

The cannon fired a projectile of 750 kilogrammes.

The two heavy guns of Predikboom and Leugenboom subjected Dunkirk to thirty two bombardments, the four hundred and eleven 15 inches shells of which killed one hundred and fourteen persons and wounded one hundred and eighty five.



COUCKELAERE.—Heavy 15 inch gun at Leugenboom.

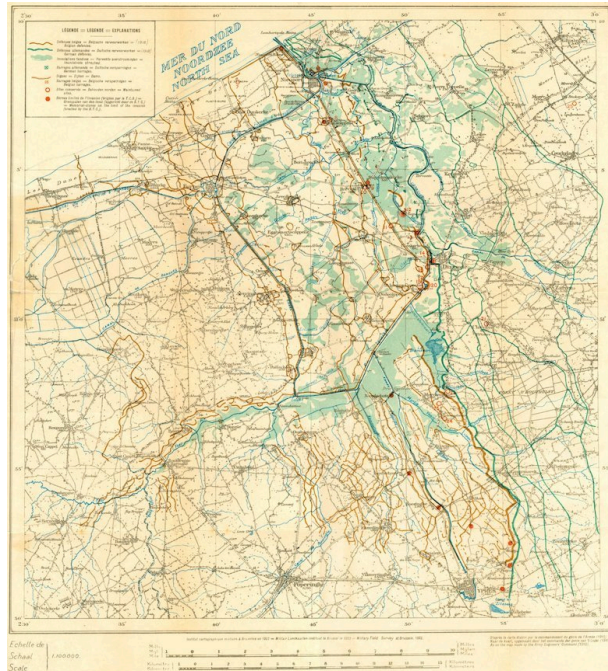


CAESKERKE.—Arched communication trench and light railway line (1916).

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ZEEBRUGGE: Sketch showing the blocking of the harbour	<u>13</u>

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SLAGVELD AAN DEN IJZER—
BATTLEFIELD OF THE YSER.

PUBLICATIONS

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BELGIAN WAR SITES DEPARTMENT

(English translation of the French text, written by the Army General Staff).

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TRANSCRIBER'S NOTES

Page	Changed from	Changed to
12	propeller got entangled in the nests of the defences, rendering	propeller got entangled in the nets of the defences, rendering
12a	It was while these manœuvres were one, that Lieutenant	It was while these manœuvres were on, that Lieutenant
22	fight last the whole night long and after the most bloody	fight lasted the whole night long and after the most bloody
23	English battery composed of two 9 inches 2, guns. That	English battery composed of two 9.2 inches, guns. That
26	war guarded by two main guards i. e. Rijkenhoek and	was guarded by two main guards i. e. Rijkenhoek and
30	rendered waterproof by means of tared board, while a	rendered waterproof by means of tarred board, while a
39	But the month of may with its had and bloody days the men had to content	But the month of may with its hard and bloody days the men had to contend
43	banks, could, mounted on little boats birthed at Dixmude	banks, could, mounted on little boats berthed at Dixmude
60	at Steenstraat; duel of artillery in the region of Noordschote	at Steenstraat; duel of artillery in the region of Noordschote
69	to give it a field of tire of 157°, the axis of which	to give it a field of fire of 157°, the axis of which

- Typos fixed; non-standard spelling and dialect retained.

- Used numbers for footnotes.

***** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK NOTICES ON THE
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